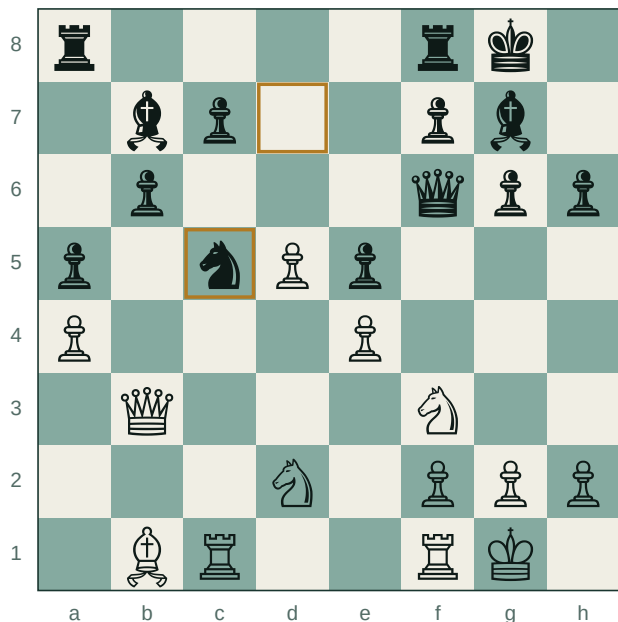


Capture the defender: White, move 22

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 21...Nc5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

22. Rxc5 bxc5 23. Qxb7

22.Rxc5 The rook captures the knight on c5. Recorded reply: **22...bxc5**.

23.Qxb7 The queen captures the bishop on b7.

At the end, nominal material is White 29 / Black 29 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +1: the balance goes from -1 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.